

Caecilians

PHYLUM	Chordata
CLASS	Amphibia
ORDER	Gymnophiona
FAMILIES	10
SPECIES	205

These limbless, wormlike animals form the smallest of the 3 major groups of amphibians. They are rarely seen by humans, because they live either in soil burrows or underwater, and are found only in humid, tropical areas. Caecilians have varied life cycles: some species lay eggs, but in others the eggs are retained in the female's body and nourished by secretions produced by the oviduct until the eggs hatch and the young are released by live birth.

Anatomy

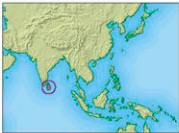
Caecilians have long, thin, black or brown to pink bodies and no limbs. They have rudimentary eyes and rely on a good sense of smell to find food and mating partners. Some resemble very large earthworms and burrow into soft soil or mud, using their pointed, bony head as a shovel. All but one species have lungs. The aquatic caecilians resemble eels; they have a fin on the tail that enables them to swim powerfully.



SENSORY TENTACLES
A unique feature of caecilians is the small tentacle located just below each eye. This collects chemical information, which is used to locate prey. Caecilians feed mainly on earthworms, which they catch with their sharp, curved teeth.

Ichthyophis glutinosus

Ceylon caecilian



Location Sri Lanka

Length Up to 18 in (45 cm)
Habit Terrestrial/Burrowing
Breeding Not known season
Status Least concern

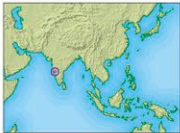


With its long, thin body covered with well-defined rings, and a short tail, the Ceylon caecilian resembles a large earthworm. It is brown with a bluish sheen, and has a pair of small, retractable tentacles between the nostrils and the eyes that enable it to pick up odors. This caecilian lives underground, mostly in muddy soil and swamps, where it feeds on worms and other invertebrates. The female coils around her eggs to protect them.



Gegeneophis mhadeiensis

Mhadei caecilian



Location India

Length 7–8 in (18–20 cm)
Habit Wholly terrestrial
Breeding Unknown season
Status Data deficient



This caecilian was described in 2008 and is known from only 3 specimens, all collected from 2 adjacent localities in the Western Ghats of India. They were found near human habitations or on agricultural land—a factor that may indicate the species can tolerate human disturbance. It is dark brown with a pinkish head, and with paler rings on its “segments.” Its habits are not known, but other members of the genus lay eggs on land and lack a larval stage.

Caecilia tentaculata

Linnaeus' caecilian



Location N. South America

Length 18–25 in (45–63 cm)
Habit Terrestrial/Burrowing
Breeding Not known season
Status Least concern



This large caecilian has a thick, flattened body, gray or black above and light brown below, and a wedge-shaped snout. It has no tail and, unlike other caecilians, its rear end is covered by a hard shield. Tiny scales are present in the skin in the 100–300 grooves that cover the body, and the tentacles, which are lower than in other caecilians, are not visible from above. Very little is known about its behavior, since it lives buried in loose soil, but it is known to be a solitary animal that lays eggs.



Dermophis mexicanus

Mexican caecilian



Location Mexico to Central America

Length 4–23½ in (10–60 cm)
Habit Terrestrial/Burrowing
Breeding Not known season
Status Vulnerable



This caecilian lives in the same region of the world as several amphisbaenians (see p.431), and is superficially similar to them, although it lacks legs. Gray, brown, or olive-green above, it has well-defined rings around its body, and a pointed, burrowing snout. It feeds chiefly on invertebrates, but also on lizards, and is completely subterranean, living in a variety of habitats where there is loose soil. The egg and larval stages are completed inside the female's body. After an extended gestation period, the mother gives birth to live young.

Siphonops annulatus

Ringed caecilian



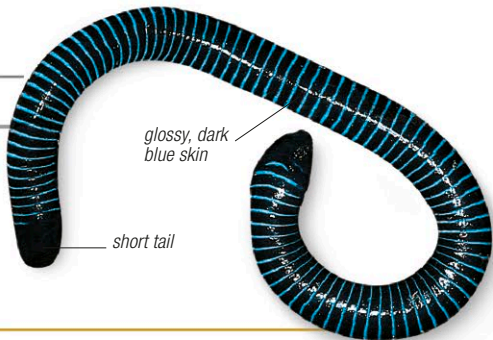
Location N. South America

Length 8–16 in (20–40 cm)
Habit Wholly terrestrial
Breeding Not known season
Status Least concern



Also known as the South American caecilian, this forest-dwelling amphibian lives in soil and resembles a large, thick earthworm. It has a relatively short, stocky, dark

blue body, encircled by white stripes and numerous rings. Like other caecilians, it uses its tentacles to pick up the odors of nearby prey—usually worms and other invertebrates. When attacked, it produces a distasteful secretion. The ringed caecilian lays its eggs in soil, where they hatch into miniature adults.



Typhlonectes compressicauda

Cayenne caecilian



Location N. South America

Length 12–23½ in (30–60 cm)
Habit Wholly aquatic
Breeding Not known season
Status Least concern



An inhabitant of rivers, lakes, and streams, the Cayenne caecilian resembles an eel in shape and the way in which it swims. It has

a long, slender, glossy black body, dark gray below, encircled by 80–95 rings. Its tail is flattened from side to side, with a slight fin along the top. The Cayenne caecilian produces toxic secretions when it is attacked, usually by fish. The eggs develop into larvae inside the body of the female, who gives birth to miniature adults.

